

SHORIGAN

AWAY FROM HOME

The First Verse

A Later Anchor Chapter

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Cyn is remembered for eleven wards and not one invitation. His line has spent a thousand years finishing what he was too afraid to start.

Anna Bell had grown very good at surviving people. She had never once let survival become a home.



I.

There was a room that existed nowhere, and both of them had built it anyway.

It sat at the exact seam where Anna Bell's Dream and Alexander's overlapped — not by accident anymore, not since the first year, when they had learned, slowly and separately and then together, exactly how much of the boundary between two dreamers could be worn thin on purpose if both of them wanted it thin. Isor had never forbidden it. He had only ever said, the one time either of them had asked, that a door used with consent stopped being a trespass and became something closer to a hallway.

They had furnished the hallway like a room. A chair from her grandmother's house in Gugulethu that did not exist anywhere in the waking world anymore, having been sold at an estate sale Anna Bell had never forgiven her uncles for arranging. A window that looked out, depending on the night, onto whichever coastline either of them missed most. A kettle that never needed refilling, because dream-kettles, unlike dream-hearts, could be generous without limit.

They had never given the room a name. Anna Bell suspected, privately, that naming it would have obligated her to admit what it already was, and she had spent three years — three years, forty-one shared Dreams, eleven battles fought on either side of a border neither of them controlled — declining to admit that.

Tonight she crossed the threshold expecting tea, and a chair, and Alexander already halfway through some story about a client's cousin's inheritance dispute that had, predictably, turned out to hinge on a badly worded Verse from four generations back.

Instead she found the window flickering between three different coastlines at once, unable to settle on one, and Alexander sitting very still in the chair from her grandmother's house, coming slowly, quietly, terribly apart.



II.

It did not look like violence. That was the first wrong thing about it.

His edges — she had no better word for it, though the Sight offered her several, none of them comforting — his edges had gone soft the way a photograph goes soft with too many years of handling. He was still recognizably himself. He was also, at the same time, faintly and unmistakably becoming other people. A stranger's laugh moved through his mouth and was gone. A woman's grief passed behind his eyes and left without asking permission. For one unbearable second he spoke in a boy's voice, thin and much too young, saying *I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I didn't mean to break it* — and then it was Alexander's own voice again, exhausted, apologizing to her instead, for something neither of them could name yet.

"You're not supposed to be able to see this part," he said, when he noticed her. He tried to smile. It did not entirely arrive on the correct face. "I usually manage to look like myself by the time anyone's watching."

Anna Bell had watched this happen slowly for three years without ever seeing it reach this far, and the not-seeing was, she understood with a coldness that had nothing to do with the flickering window, entirely her own fault. She had been the one to teach him this, after all. Not on purpose. Not even knowingly, the first time.

The first time had been an accident so small neither of them had recognized it as a beginning. A blade meant for her, taken instead by a fight that had gone wrong in the waking world eight months into knowing each other, and Alexander — new to the Realm's deeper rules, newer still to whatever he was — had reached for the wound the same rough way he had once reached for his own Rage, all commitment and no technique, except this time not to end something. To undo it. It should not have worked. He had no training for it, no Verse, nothing but the same total unbargaining willingness that had once let him strike at a thing wearing Anna Bell's voice.

It had worked anyway. Her wound had simply — stopped being a wound. And something in Alexander, watching that happen, had learned a shape it did not yet have a name for, in the exact wordless way a body learns to walk by falling enough times in a room that happens to be soft.

After that, it had never again been an accident. He had practiced it deliberately — first on the smaller cruelties memory kept reopening in him, the shame from a fight he'd lost to Lust once and never quite forgiven himself for, the humiliation Distraction had left folded into every unfinished thing he touched. He had learned, doing that, that healing himself and healing a stranger were the same gesture aimed in different directions. And so, over three years, in dreams neither of them had told anyone about, Alexander had quietly become something the old training texts did not have a

clean word for. Not a Namer. Not a warrior in any sense Anna Bell's discipline recognized. Something closer to a debt collector working in reverse, going from dreamer to dreamer, undoing what he could of what the Adversaries left behind, paying out of himself each time, and never once — this was the part that frightened her most, now, watching him flicker between three coastlines and a stranger's borrowed grief — asking anyone to pay him back.

"How many," Anna Bell said. Not *are you all right*. She had learned, three years in, that the question he could actually answer was always the specific one.

"I stopped counting around the same time I stopped telling you," Alexander admitted, and this, finally, was entirely his own voice, tired all the way down. "I think that might have been the mistake."



III.

The window steadied on a coastline neither of them recognized, which was somehow worse than the flickering, because it meant something in the room besides Alexander had stopped being certain what it belonged to.

"How generous," said a voice from the doorway that had not existed a moment before, and had clearly always been there. "I do so love a debt that collects itself."

Lady Loss did not enter so much as the room admitted it had always contained her, the way Anna Bell's dream-café had always contained the thread around her ankle, waiting to be noticed. She looked, tonight, unhurried in a way that felt worse than urgency — the look of a creditor who has already seen the ledger and is simply enjoying watching the debtor discover it.

"He's not yours to collect from," Anna Bell said, and heard, with some distant part of herself, how instantly and how completely she had put her own body between Lady Loss and the chair. Three years ago she would have thought first, chosen the sentence for its precision, weighed the cost of provoking a principle older than the Verses. Tonight she had simply moved.

"No," Lady Loss agreed, entirely unbothered. "He isn't. He's paying a debt that was never his to begin with, which is, I'll admit, the single most interesting thing your bloodline has produced in four generations. Cyn owed me a grief he refused to feel, little Namer. He built eleven wards instead and called the matter closed. It was never closed. Debts like that don't vanish. They wait for someone soft enough to mistake them for their own — and your Alexander, bless the shape of him, has spent three years quietly paying interest on a debt that has your family's name on it and none of his own."

The room went very still. Even the kettle stopped its patient, endless simmering.

"That's not possible," Anna Bell said, though the Sight, unbidden, was already showing her the shape of it — a thread, thin as the one Lust had once tied to her ankle, running not from Alexander to some stranger's healed grief, but backward, through every dream he had quietly emptied himself into, all the way to a debt with her own family's weight braided through its core. "He's not blood. He can't be carrying Cyn's ledger."

"He isn't carrying the ledger," Lady Loss said, with the particular patience of someone explaining a rule for the second time to a student who is nearly, but not quite, clever enough to have gotten there alone. "He's carrying *you*. Every time he emptied himself into someone else's wound, some part of what he spent came from what you'd already given him — which was more than either of you noticed giving. You've been pouring yourself into that man for three years and calling it friendship, little Namer. He has been quietly spending your overflow to keep strangers whole. Eventually a vessel that only ever pours and is never once filled runs dry, and I confess, I have been looking forward to watching which one of you noticed first."



Lady Luck arrived the way the second half of a held breath arrives — not summoned, only overdue.

"Don't let her make it sound so grim," she said, delighted, settling herself against the window frame as though she had been leaning there the whole time and simply waited for someone to notice. "Three years, and neither of you has said the plain thing to the other, and now here we all are at the exact hour it can't be avoided any longer. I do love an overdue bill. It always collects the most interesting way."

"This isn't a game to you," Anna Bell said.

"Everything is a game to me," Lady Luck said, entirely without apology. "That's rather the point of me. But I'll tell you something she won't, because she enjoys the suspense too much to spoil it. You already know what he needs. You've known it since the wound that started all this, three years ago, and you have spent every single night since finding a more elegant way to avoid doing it. I find that, in its own way, more romantic than anything either of you has managed to say out loud. But romance doesn't hold a man's shape together, little Namer. Only the plain thing does."



IV.

The Sight, when Anna Bell finally let it look at the whole of him rather than flinching from any single part, showed her something she recognized instantly and did not want to.

Alexander was not being unmade by an Adversary. No Rage stood over him tonight, no Lust, no Distraction wearing a borrowed face. He was simply hollow — the specific, quiet hollowness of a person who has spent three years pouring everything outward and has never once, not a single time, let anyone pour anything back in. He had learned to heal from watching her hold a wound alone and refuse help. He had learned the lesson perfectly. He had learned the flaw in it just as perfectly, and had never once noticed, because the flaw wore the shape of generosity, and generosity does not announce itself as a wound the way the chain around her own shoulders had.

He is doing to himself, she realized, with the particular vertigo of watching a mirror finish a sentence you had started, *exactly what I did to myself for twenty-seven years. He simply learned it from me instead of from his own family, and he is dying of it faster, because he never had a lifetime to build the calluses I built.*

This was, she understood, the actual debt Lady Loss had come to collect. Not a grief owed by Cyn's bloodline in the abstract. A grief owed, specifically, by her — the grief of never once letting anyone see the chain, transmitted forward, without her consent and entirely by example, into a man who loved her enough to learn her worst habit and mistake it for a virtue.

The word *loved* arrived in her own thought so plainly, so without ceremony, that she almost missed it going by. She caught it a half-second too late, the way you catch, a half-second too late, that you have already stepped off a curb you meant to stop at.

She did not say it aloud. She noted, with the same cold clarity that had once told her a rope was only rope if addressed correctly, that not saying it aloud was itself the exact shape of the mistake she was trying to stop repeating.



V.

"I know what this is," she said, to the room, to Lady Loss, to Lady Luck leaning delighted against the window, to Alexander, whose eyes had found hers and were, for the moment, entirely his own. "I know what you're waiting for."

"Then say it," Lady Loss said, and for the first time all night there was something almost gentle underneath the appetite. "Not to me. I already know it. Say it so the two of you remember you're the ones who know it too."

Anna Bell had spent twenty-seven years building a discipline whose entire foundation was this: that a Name kept was a Name protected, that the highest sorcery a Namer of her line could practice was the perfect, permanent concealment of the one word that could be used against her. She had believed this so completely that she had never once asked the second question — what a Name kept

from *everyone*, including the person who loved you enough to learn your worst habit by watching, actually cost.

Isor had told her, three years ago, in an ash-colored ruin of a dream she still dreamed about more often than she admitted: *A Name kept from every enemy is a discipline. A Name kept from yourself is a kind of dying no Adversary needs to arrange.*

She had understood that sentence, she realized now, only halfway. She had understood it as being about herself. She had never understood that a Name withheld from someone who has already given you three years of himself, without asking anything back, is not protection at all. It is theft, committed slowly, against the one person who never once tried to steal it.

The First Verse was not a spell. It had never been a spell. It was the sentence she had refused to finish since the night Rage first found her chain, the sentence every Namer of her line had refused to finish since Cyn built eleven wards instead of one invitation.

She knelt beside the chair, the way she had once knelt in ash-light before a thing wearing her own voice, and took Alexander's flickering hand in both of hers, and found — with no small wonder — that her own hands did not shake.

"Alexander," she said, and it was the first time in three years she had said his name meaning to accomplish something with it rather than simply to speak to him. "I need you to hear something, and I need you to stay long enough to hear all of it."

He held, for her, the way a man holds his breath for someone he trusts more than his own lungs.

She said her own Name.



VI.

It did not sound like power when it left her. It sounded, if anything, like an apology three years overdue, spoken in a voice she had not used since Gugulethu, since before Nomsa Adaeze, since before eleven wards had seemed like the only inheritance worth keeping.

The room did not shatter, the way she had half-expected some part of her armor to shatter after a lifetime spent building it. It simply — opened. The way a held breath opens into an ordinary one. The way a fist, after years, remembers it was also a hand.

She felt the Mantle complete before she understood that it had a name for what it was doing. Her Presence, which had spent a lifetime pulling rooms toward her without ever once letting anything settle inside the pull, extended now — not outward to command attention, but sideways, the way one flame leans into a second flame without either of them losing their own shape. She felt

the hollow, flickering, over-poured shape of Alexander come to rest inside the reach of her, held, not absorbed, the specific difference between carrying someone and consuming them finally, physically, undeniably clear to her for the first time in her life. His edges stopped shifting between strangers. His voice, when it came, was entirely his own.

"I can feel you holding it," he said, wonderingly, meaning the strangers' griefs still lodged in him, the years of quiet overflow. "You're not taking it out of me. You're just—"

"Standing close enough that you don't have to hold all of it alone," Anna Bell said, and heard, in her own sentence, the ghost of the one he had once said to her, in ash-light, before either of them understood what they were building toward. *That's not yours to carry alone*. He had said it to save her from a debt she couldn't see. She was saying it back, three years and a lifetime of stubbornness later, to save him from the debt he'd inherited from watching her survive.

The Throne arrived the way authority arrives when it is offered rather than seized — not guilt, not marble, simply the unmistakable structural weight of a woman standing in the full authority of everything she was, in front of a witness who was not there to take it from her. Anna Bell rose from her knees inside that weight, exposed in a way three years of careful friendship had never once required of her, and let Alexander watch her be entirely, unguardedly herself — Namer, descendant of a man who built wards instead of doors, a woman who had just spent the one thing she had spent a lifetime refusing to spend — and did not flinch from being seen doing it.



VII.

"There," said Lady Loss, and her voice, for the first time all night, held something that was not quite hunger. "That's the debt paid. Not to me. I never actually wanted the coin I asked for, little Namer — that's the part your bloodline has never understood in a thousand years of building wards against me. I don't collect grief because I enjoy the taking. I collect it because so very few of you ever actually feel it long enough to hand it over honestly. Cyn built eleven wards rather than grieve one lost thing plainly, and so the debt sat, uncollected, for four generations, gathering interest nobody was paying down. You just paid down four generations of interest in under a minute, and you didn't even do it for me. You did it for him. I find that, against every instinct I have, rather moving."

"I don't feel forgiven," Anna Bell said, honestly, because honesty, tonight, appeared to be the only currency left in her purse.

"You're not meant to feel forgiven," Lady Loss said. "You're meant to feel lighter. Those are different currencies, and only one of them was ever actually owed."

"I told you," Lady Luck said, delighted beyond any pretense of restraint, "that the plain thing was the only thing that would hold him together. I do love being right about the interesting part." She glanced toward the doorway, where the air had gone very slightly still in the particular way it always did before Isor arrived, and did not arrive.

"He's not coming tonight," she added, almost gently, for her. "I don't think he's needed. I think, for the first time in three years, the two of you actually finished something without him having to referee it."



VIII.

The room settled, the window steadying at last on the one coastline that belonged to neither of them exactly and both of them completely — a shore built, Anna Bell understood now, from three years of a hallway neither of them had ever agreed to call a home.

Alexander's hand was still in both of hers. His edges held. His voice, when he found it, was entirely, unmistakably his own.

"You've never said your Name to anyone," he said. Not a question. He had learned, three years in, which of her sentences were actually questions.

"No," Anna Bell said.

"Why me. Tonight."

She had an answer ready, the way she had spent a lifetime keeping an answer ready for every question that came near the true one — something about debts, about Cyn, about the mechanics of the Mantle requiring a witness, all of it true, none of it the whole of it.

"Because you spent three years pouring yourself into strangers rather than ask me for anything back," she said instead, "and I let you, because asking would have meant admitting what I'd have to feel if you ever stopped."

The sentence hung between them, entirely unfinished, in exactly the shape of every sentence she had refused to finish since a night in ash-light when a stranger had said her Name without meaning to and she had answered him with every weapon she owned. He was close enough now that finishing it would have cost her nothing technical and everything else. She watched him understand that. She watched him decide, the same way he had once decided against Rage, not to spend anything that wasn't his to spend — to wait, unhurried, for her to be the one who chose.

"Say the rest of it," he said, quietly. Not a demand. An offer, the kind a man makes when he already knows the answer is his to wait for and not his to take.

Anna Bell, who had just spent the one thing she had spent twenty-seven years refusing to spend, found that the rest of the sentence was, after all, still hers to keep for one more night.

"Not yet," she said.

It was not a refusal. Even Lady Luck, watching from the window with an expression that suggested she would be back for exactly this unfinished sentence sooner than either of them expected, seemed to understand that it was not a refusal.

They did not kiss.

They sat instead in the one room that had never needed a name to be theirs, and let the kettle, which required nothing and forgave everything, begin, at last, to boil.



IX.

Isor, when Anna Bell woke, was not there either, which she understood, lying very still in the grey Cape Town dawn with her own Name settled inside her chest like a stone finally set down rather than carried, to be its own kind of teaching.

Some lessons, she thought, he only needed to arrange the conditions for. The rest, apparently, a person had to be trusted to finish on her own.

She did not answer her mother's voicemail that morning either. But for the first time in three years, she thought about what she might actually say, if she called back — not the schedule of her return, not the excuses about work, but the plain thing, the way Alexander had once offered it to her and she had, at last, learned to offer it back.

Not yet, she thought, and found, to her own quiet astonishment, that the words no longer felt like a wall.

They felt, for the first time in longer than she could name, like a door — closed for tonight, but no longer warded.